The Dark Swordsman:

The Beginning of the End

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Overview

Goals

Internal goal

- witnessing a thrilling story in an authentic set up of the game
- enjoy the visuals of the game
- think about their life (as in the game multiple psychosocial questions are up)
- get well with realistic fighting mechanic

External goal

- transfer the story from my mind into actual prototype
- try my strength in narrative design;
- get evidence for future career;

Gameplay goals

- finish the plot of the game; beat the bosses during the game; complete multiple levels

Target Audience (16+ yo)

Fans of Dark Fantasy: Players who enjoy immersive, narrative-driven worlds with a heavy focus on combat, exploration, and lore.

Players who appreciate character-driven stories: Players who are interested in emotional depth, character development, and psychological themes such as revenge, regret, and redemption.

Action-Oriented Gamers: Those who enjoy challenging combat mechanics, including sword fighting and boss battles.

Fans of Linear games : Players who like linear games and are tired of big open world games, where you need to spend at least 40 hours to finish it. This game will focus mainly on story with additional mechanics to make that playthrough more interesting and engaging.

Mature Audiences: Given the game's focus on themes of loss, revenge, and regret, the target audience will lean toward adults or older teens who can appreciate deeper, more complex storytelling.

Players interested in immersive atmospheric experiences: Those who are drawn to games with a dark, brooding atmosphere and intense, immersive world-design.
Fans of StoryBased Games: Gamers who enjoy stories that develop gradually and have a thought-provoking, introspective conclusion that challenges the player's perception of fate and destiny.

Platform PC, 3D Game. Release platform - Steam. Programmed in Unity or UnrealEngine;

Genre: Adventure; Dark Fantasy; Cinematic; First Person fighter; Story rich;

Story

Setting and story of the game is set in old times (like Elden Ring, Lord of the rings etc.). The game will tell the story about one knight ("the Dark Swordsman"). He needs to destroy all the demons to become free again and mortal, as demons won't let him die for a long time. By telling this story players will feel different emotions, as the game narration touches philosophical questions about the meaning and purpose of life.

Character

The Black Swordsman, who onced been cursed by demons to live forever in torture. During that long term life he is fighting them not just outside of the world (by helping different kingdoms) but inside himself, which sometimes could cause innocent death.

To not starve and have money, he works for different kingdoms as a soldier in the wars between them to get some money.

Gameplay

The gameplay gives an opportunity to try a new realistic fighting mechanic, as most of the game players will use the infamous black sword. The unique feature of this gameplay is not just with fighting mechanics on swords, but also realism of that process, as if you got hit by a sword (for example in the heart) you will die, there is no HP for the player and who is against him. Furthermore, the player will be fully engaged with the story, as there will be a lot of cinematic cutscenes. The gameplay type is linear, as the player mainly will go by the plot and complete multiple levels with different mechanics of it.

Atmosphere & Visual Design

The atmosphere is a balance between dark fantasy, psychological horror, and emotional depth, designed to make players feel both the weight of the protagonist's past and the oppressive environment he's trapped in.

Main Mechanics

- Combat: Players will wield a sword to fight off enemies, with mechanics involving attacking & defending to defeat various types of demons and soldiers.
- Exploration: Players will explore different environments such as forests, villages, and warfields, interacting with NPCs and discovering the lore.
- Cut scenes: During the game player will see different motion cutscene, as it's more story based game and atmosphere.

User Experience

- Immersive World: Players will experience a dark, atmospheric world where every action feels significant. The emotional weight of the protagonist's journey, including moments of regret and self-reflection, will encourage players to connect with his struggles.
- Impact: The moral complexity of the protagonist's choices, especially during the pivotal moments (like the decision to visit his old love), will make players reflect on their own choices in real life.
- Emotional Engagement: The game will take players on a rollercoaster of emotions, from the protagonist's past love to the final philosophical reflections about fate and self-determination. These moments will make players question the nature of revenge, redemption, and what it means to truly live.

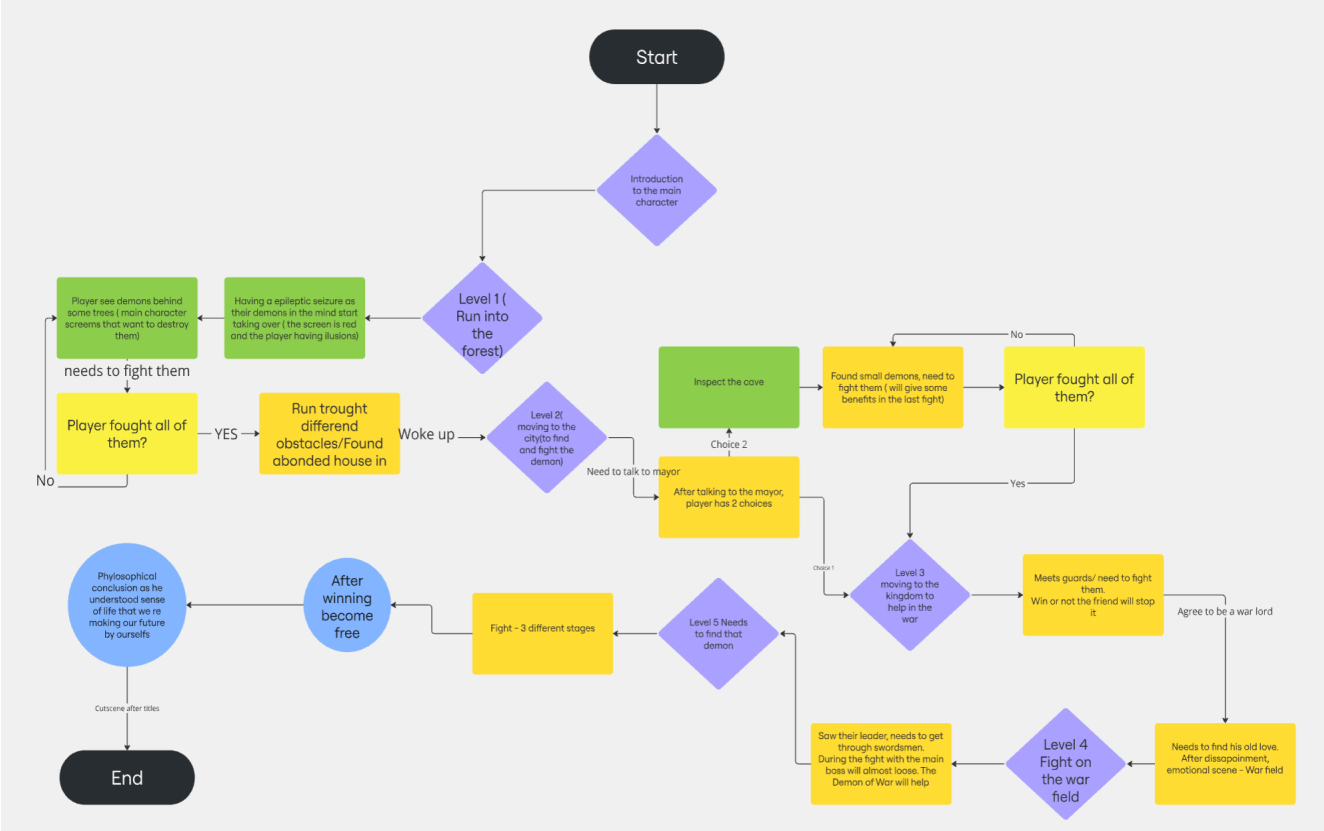
Level Design

Flowchart

In order to understand the logic of levels and provide clarity, I created a flowchart, so it would be much easier to develop in the future and understand the scope of the

project. Moreover, it helps to understand the real objectives of the level.

In addition, it would help to organize the project and make it true to its intended design from start to finish.



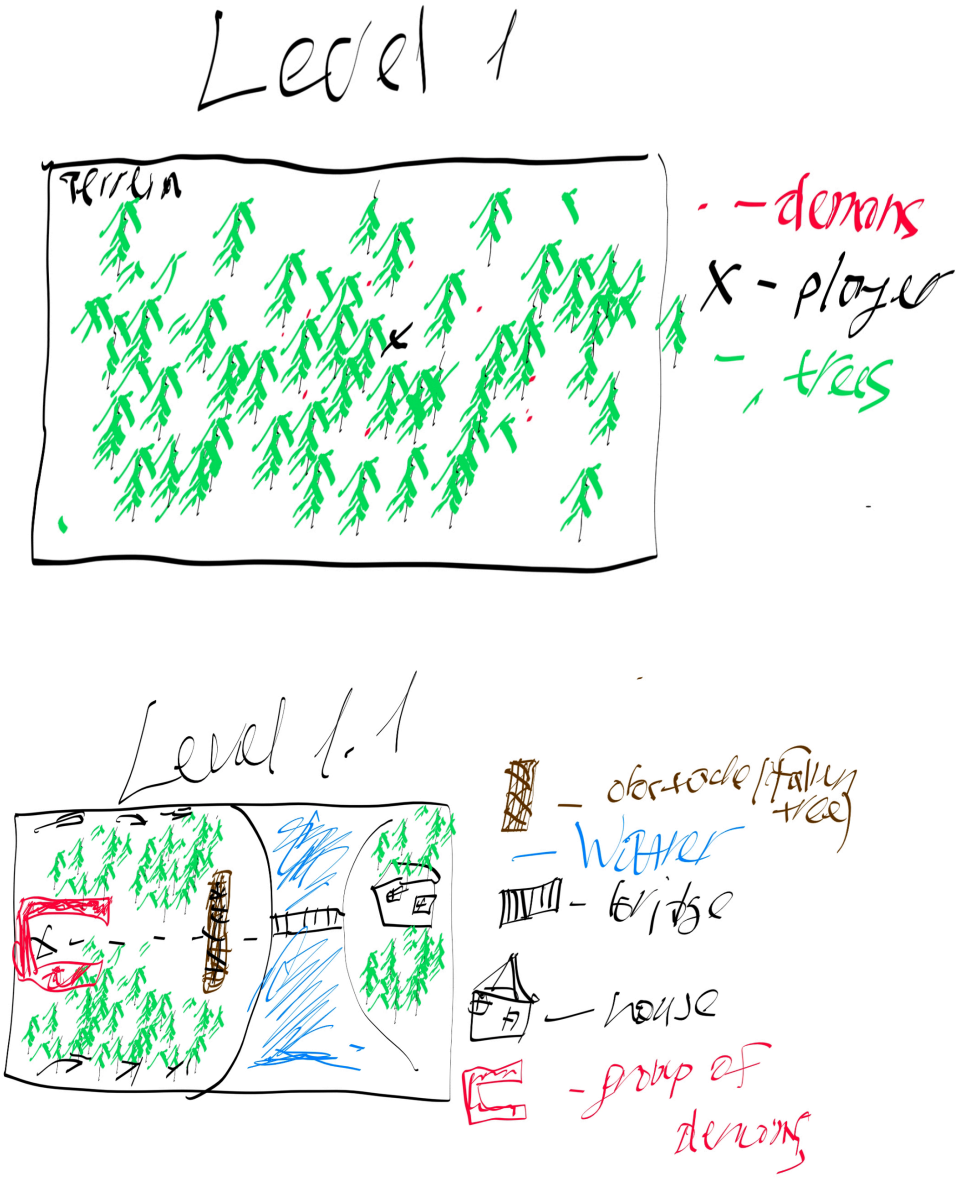
In order to develop the game, I created the beat chart with all the elements levels will have. So easily in any time the developers could remove something or add. In addition, it's better to look at the game to see the full picture.

“The Dark Swordsman: The Start of the End” - Beat chart					
Elements	Level 1	Level 2	Level 3	Level 4	Level 5
Location	Forest	Village & Demon cave	Kingdom of light	War field	Top of the hill
Gameplay	Fighting & Running through obstacles	Talking to npcs, trying small activates & fighting	Fighting guardians, Explore the town & talk to npc	Fighting the opposite army & having a boss fight with their leader	Fighting last demon (3 phases)
Objective	Destroy all real demons(5 with the red smog after)	Find a mayor & Get information about demon & Inspect the cave	Talk to his old friend , Become a warlord & Find old love	Win the war & Find the “Demon of War”	Win final fight in order to become free and break the curse
Mechanics	Fighting with sword & Press buttons in time	Dialogues with npcs/Fighting	Fighting, Dialogues with npcs	Fighting with sword & Press button in time	Finding demon by traces & Fighting with sword
Story beat	Dark swordsman needs to destroy demons, until they cloud his mind	Protagonist needs to find the demon as he heard rumors that he might be there from magazine	After hearing about the war between, he decided to go there in order to help. After becoming a warlord, the protagonist decided to meet his old	The protagonist will participate in war in order to find the last Demon to get himself finally free. During his boss fight he will almost loose, but that	Final moment in the game, the dark swordsman will have to face his final enemy. After killing the leader of the opposite army, he will find the demon by his traces and fight him on the top of

“The Dark Swordsman: The Start of the End” - Beat chart					
Elements	Level 1	Level 2	Level 3	Level 4	Level 5
			love for the last time. But after seeing her, he decided to not do it anymore.	demon will help him to win	the hill. Shortly after winning that fight, he will say his last speech in the game. END
Enemies	Demons	Small demons	4 Guardians	Army from the opposite kingdom & Their leader	Demon of War
NPC	NONE	Villagers, Mayor	Citizens, Magician, Old love	Protagonist army	NONE
Time of day	Moon Night	Cloudy day	Day & Evening	Cloudy morning	Day

Map of level

Before recreating the level, I drew 2 sketches which are representing my finished levels. It helped to understand the size of the level and what elements I need to create. Furthermore, it helped to understand how long it should take to complete the level, based on activities I have.



Start of the game

Introduction to the main character

The first thing that the player would see after launching the game, is a scene where the main antagonist fights the

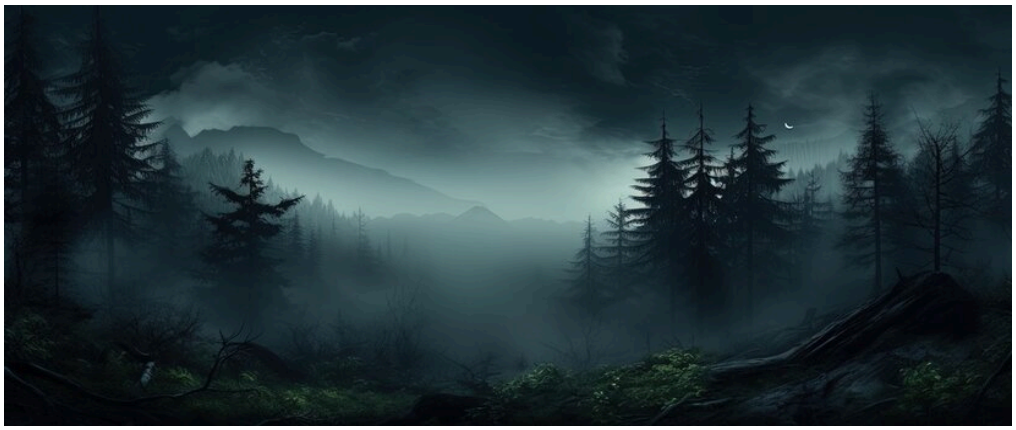
demon with their dialogs which are consistent with previous interaction. It will be the ending of the game, but of course players would not know it yet. (Basically like in the movie **Memento**, **Eternal Sunshine of the spotless mind, Fight club etc)**

Level 1

After the introduction the player will witness a motion scene where the protagonist is running through the woods with noisy voices in his head in the surroundings of small demons hiding behind trees. After that the player will be introduced to how to use main mechanics such as taking out the sword, moving, fighting and interacting.

During that level the player will have a task to catch and destroy demons until their voices will disappear, the longer it takes, the crazier the player becomes and it will be harder for them to see clearly.

Forest:



After finishing it, the player will have a cutscene at which the protagonist will start running from them (as the amount of demons will increase). Players will need to run through different obstacles, and find an abandoned house and lock in there. Slightly after that the protagonist will fall asleep and the player will see the name of the game.

Level 2

When a player sees the title, it will slowly transite to motion scene where antagonist will look at the magazine cut where it says “Searching for a swordsman to solve the problem that has been placed in the village, animals and people are missing on regularly, we’re hopeless and will pay as much as you ask for help”.

After showing it to the player the antagonist will mention that it's the demon sights that he has been hunting for a long time and must continue his way there as it is only 2 miles to that place, and the load screen will appear as fast as the antagonist stands up and goes away.

Next location is that village, the player will see how the antagonist is riding into the village at that time "transport".

Furthermore, the player will start playing and will need to find a person from that piece of magazine, to get that job. So the player will have a bit of time to explore that village, ask some questions to other people about those incidents and where he can find that guy.

Also there will be a chance to play some mini interactions with these villagers, such as poker in the bar, train with

someone on wood swords etc. These interactions will help to get extra info (“Play with me poker and maybe I will tell you something about it” etc.).

After getting enough information, the player will find that person (the mayor) at the end of that village. That npc will tell you about that creature which has been murdering and

kidnapping people of that village. In his monologue he will mention the location where that demon used to live (as now it disappeared). At the end he will mention the war that is in active phase right now between 2 kingdoms, and that he should be careful nowadays and be safe.

At the end, the player will have a choice, rather move to "Kingdom of light" now, or explore the demon's cave and its surrounding to get more info about it. Also some of the little demons will still be in that cave, so players will have to fight them in order to practise more.

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Level 3

The next location of that adventure is a Kingdom of Light. Beforehand the player will see a cutscene where the main antagonist sends a letter with a pigeon to his old friend, who lives there and serves as a magician of that Kingdom. At the end the Dark Swordsman gets on a horse and moves there.

After getting in the kingdom, he gets informed by a boy that his friend is waiting for him in the bar at the "Light avenue" right before he enters the kingdom, which is the next destination for him.

Right after he enters, it seems that some guards still remember him and start a conflict because of their old grievances. Player needs to fight 4 of them, after almost finishing the last guardian, his old friend will show up and interrupt the fight, and approach him to the main castle to introduce to the king.

After getting into the showroom with the leaders of its army and king itself, the protagonist agrees to become their warlord who will be ahead of it. As in the talk with the magician, he gets to know a fact, that the last lord demon he's been looking for had been seen recently around it.

That demon is known as a Demon of War (he shows up only during the global wars to collect their souls, so he could become stronger), so it's most likely that he'll show up that time too.

But, before going to the war the protagonist needs to visit his old love for the last time, as he might not survive in the fight against the Demon of war. Player will have plenty of

time to explore the city, as he needs to find information about where she lives right now, as her old building has been destroyed and replaced with a bar. So the player needs to go in that area and ask different people about her and where she could move. During that time the player could also do some side missions.

After he gets to know where she lives, the player will see a cutscene, when it's already dark outside and the protagonist will look in the window of her house which is full of light where he will see his love. Shortly after he wants to get closer, a man shows up into the room with flowers, with the kids. He sees her happy and having a wonderful life with a husband and kids. His fists have clenched, and the blood from his injury on it has started bleeding, the eyes become wet. At that moment his heart was beating for the first time in the past years. This is an important moment in the game, as this is the first time the player will see the main protagonist, the infamous warrior, in tears. It's the moment when he realised, even though he's lived on that planet for more than 100 years, he has never appreciated the moments he could have with people he loves, because of his obsession with revenge. In the moment where a few steps are left to finish what he was doing, he starts regretting

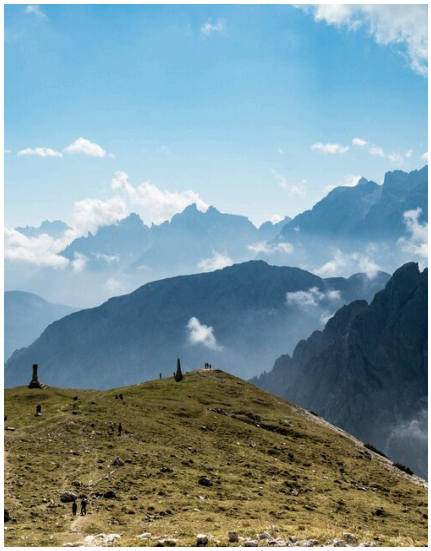
it, and just wishes he could have a bit more time with her in the past. That moment brings up a philosophical question about life, how we're not appreciating our time, and how it is hurtful to realize it at the last moment, when it's already too late. This is the first and last time a player will see him like that.

At the end he stands up and kindly puts her picture on the floor and goes into the darkness of an empty street full of the mog.

Level 4

The war field, this is the start of the end. During that level players will fight against other soldiers to get through all of them to fight their leader, which will be the boss fight.

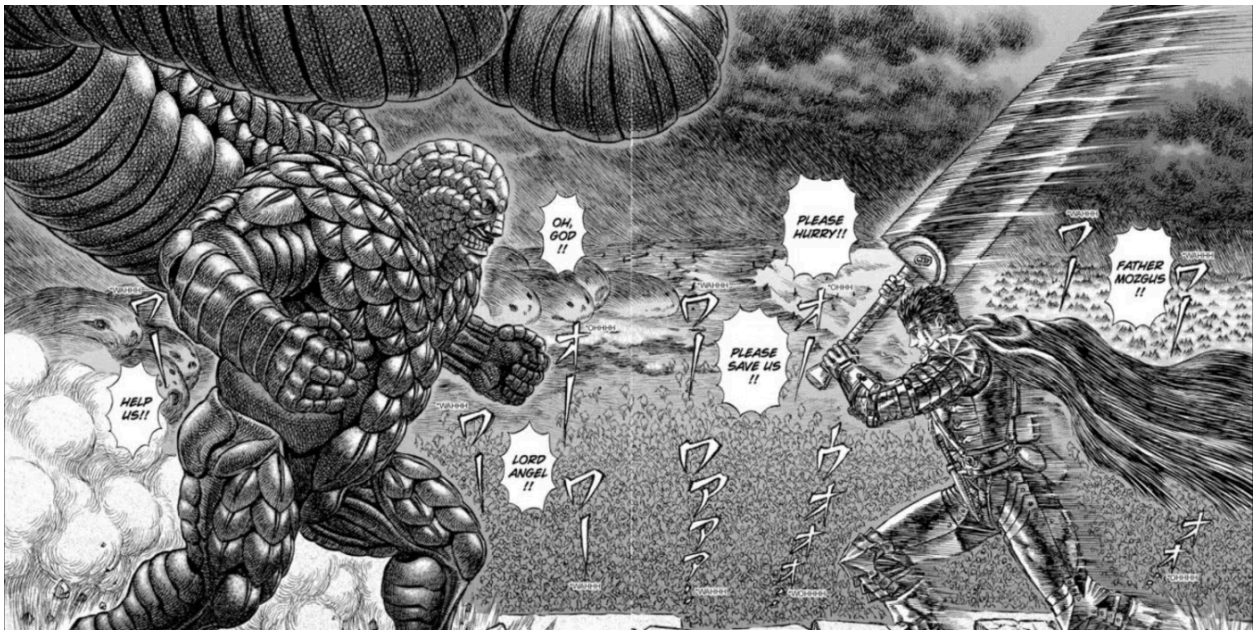
After killing multiple soldiers, the player will notice their leader in the distance, at that moment the player's task will be to run into him. During their fight, it'll be impossible to win at some point, after player will got 50% of that boss hp, the cutscene will be played, where that enemy throw the sword out of the main character hands, and on the hill on another side of the war field, the demon will appear and throw his sword to the main protagonist, helping him to win that fight and war.



Level 5

Right after that, the player will need to leave the war field and find the demon by his traces in the forest. After finding

him on top of the hill, the last fight will be started. The fight will have 3 different stages, as this is the most important fight in the game.



After winning that fight, the dark swordsman finally becomes free, and his tortured life ends. Shortly after victory, player will see final cutscene, where player will sit at the end of hill and saying his final words - “ All my life I have been blinded by revenge, mindlessly wandering the world in search of the meaning of my life, blindly believing that my life is doomed and there is only one path for me. In fact, it’s me who was the poison that prevented me from living freely. Now I realize this, it is not fate that tells us how to live, but we are the fate that determines us”. Right after these words, the screen will go out, and credits start showing.

After the credits ended, I would show them the empty cliff without the protagonist, that would open the question about the ending, as his last words would feel nonordinary. Did he die? What happened next?

Controls(instruction for the level 1) :

Walking - WASD;
Take sword out - “F”;
Hit with sword - “Right mouse click”;

Future Development:

In my future development, I would create a prequel where the story would be shown from the start, so players not just know the whole story, but also would want to replay this game again, as with much more understanding, it will feel different - “The Dark Swordsman - “TITLE”

After realizing a prequel, I would create the final chapter of this game, that will continue the story and end it fully. This

move might surprise my possible fans, as most likely that what they would like to see, as the story would not end fully yet - “The Dark Swordsman - “TITLE”

Furthemore, I would write a whole series of books/comics about that story. To not just sell it to the fans, but also bring new people into the game, who might be interested in playing it, after reading the books.

Testing Prototype:

- Prototype is fine, just keep doing it. But be aware of explanations to the players, and time waste during the first half of the level 1. Also it would be great to have self talking to the game (either subtitle, or Ai voice acting)
- Looks great, has not much to say, but be sure that you explained the backstory before level starts, I was a bit confused about what is going on.
- Get rid of the sprint as it would much scarier, needed sounds. Lots of feedback after you hit demons . Maybe lock fps to 60 so it will not have a difference in speed ; Remove the sprint! Add sounds.